

SWEET AND SOUR

Based on real life stories, the book manages to capture the mood of the period when the Chinese lived and flourished in Calcutta



THE LAST DRAGON DANCE: CHINATOWN STORIES

by KWAI-YUN LI

Penguin

Price: Rs 199; Pages: 122

■ By Dilip Bobb

Calcutta has played host to a number of émigré communities attracted to the city for reasons of economics, history, politics and geography. The most visible were the Chinese, the Armenians and the Jewish community. While the Jews and Armenians were relatively affluent and concentrated in the area around Park Street, the Chinese, numbering some 30,000—the largest—took up jobs that came naturally to them and the locals shunned: leather tanneries for shoemaking, hair-dressing, furniture-making and eateries. (It was at his Calcutta restaurant on Park Street that Nelson Wang invented Manchurian Chicken.) Calcutta was probably the first city in India to have an official Chinatown where tiny outdoor stalls manned by oversized women served up some mouth-watering Chinese cuisine. It was even called

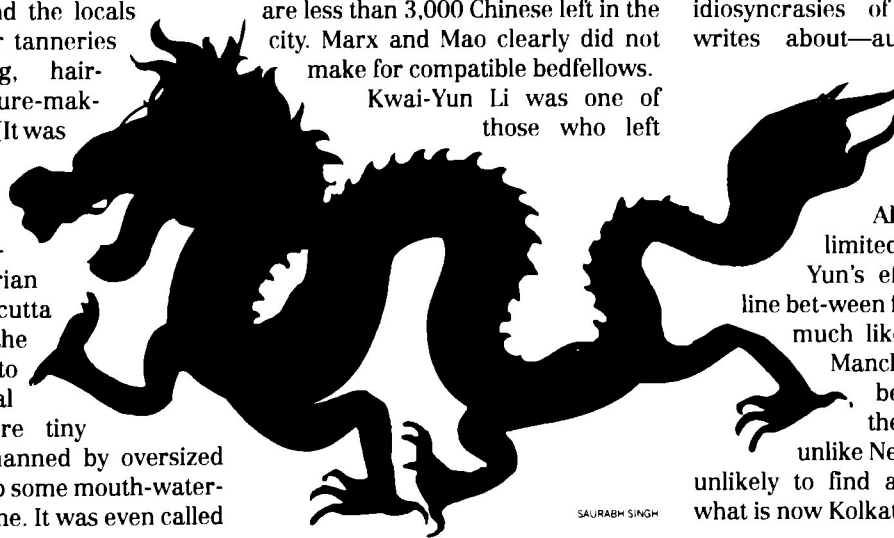
Sun Yat Sen Street. A large number of Chinese owned or worked in the tanneries in Kangra which supplied shoes and leather goods for the row of shops in Bentinck Street while the rest migrated to Bow Bazaar in north Calcutta, a lower middle-class enclave.

By the 1950s, they had become an integral part of the city's cultural and commercial landscape while preserving their distinct identity and customs. The Indo-China conflict and West Bengal's economic decline that started in the late '70s proved a turning point for the community. Hostility and mistrust forced a gradual exodus, and the closure of the tanneries by the state government in 2002 for environmental reasons proved the final nail in the coffin. Today, there are less than 3,000 Chinese left in the city. Marx and Mao clearly did not make for compatible bedfellows.

Kwai-Yun Li was one of those who left

Calcutta for Canada when she was 22, eventually to become a writer. She was, however, born and brought up in the city and this is her account of the Chinese émigré experience in Calcutta, based on real life stories and anecdotes. Though a slim volume and somewhat disjointed, Li manages to capture the mood of the time through the lives and experiences of families and individuals who were representative of the Chinese community, some sweet, some sour. Belonging to the latter category is her account of the trauma the Chinese community went through in the aftermath of the Indo-China conflict when midnight knocks by the West Bengal Police were an everyday occurrence. Many of them were deported to China and others were interned in special camps on suspicion of being spies for the Chinese government, even though none of the Chinese living in Calcutta had any interest in the politics of Mao Tse Tung and Chang Kai Shek.

Largely, however, the stories are to do with the personalities and idiosyncrasies of the people she writes about—aunts, uncles and friends, while accurately bringing out the unique flavour of the city in that era. Although a subject of limited interest, Kwai-Yun's effort straddles the line between fact and fiction, and much like Nelson's famous Manchurian Chicken, has been adapted to suit the Indian palate. But unlike Nelson's creation, it is unlikely to find acceptance beyond what is now Kolkata. ■



SAURABH SINGH

NEW RELEASES



ITALIAN KHANA

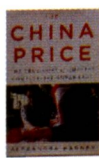
by RITU DALMIA

Random House

Price: Rs 750

Pages: 239

A celebrity restaurateur-chef who specialises in Italian cuisine, Dalmia's first cook book answers all questions about cooking authentic Italian food in Indian kitchen along with details about regional specialties and accompaniments.



THE CHINA PRICE: THE TRUE COST OF CHINESE COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE

by ALEXANDRA HARNEY

Penguin Press

Price: \$15; Pages: 336

An engrossing tale of Dickensian industrialisation, the book explores the hidden price tag for China's economic juggernaut. Packed with sympathetic portraits of Chinese workers, it is a perceptive take on the world's workshop.



TREES OF INDIA

by PIPPA MUKHERJEE

Oxford

Price: Rs 195

Pages: 99

A part of the four-book Nature Guide series, it is an introduction to everything you wanted to know about common Indian trees. Others in the series include *Butterflies of India*, *Fishes of India* and *Seashore Life of India*.